

An Apple a day... is not enough!

For quite some time now, the world has been app crazy, this isn't news to anyone. At first it was just Apple users going app crazy, because so few of us could afford those devices. It wasn't just the US and Europe that went Apple crazy, our annual Icons of Trust survey also had people ooh-ing and aah-ing over Apple devices, even though only a tiny minority owned them.

That's the power of being considered "cool" and "trendy", in your own words. After the runaway success of the iPod models, the iPhone was obviously going to sell like hot cakes. When the iPhone released, a lot of us were disgusted with our phones, I know I was – I wanted to break my SE K850i into 5 million pieces. The only thing that stopped me was the 5 million pixels the camera could click at, with a flash – which the iPhone just got, I might add.

Today's fashion is tomorrow's rags however. This was evident from market share reports from the US mobile industry, which showed that almost half of all mobiles sold were Android based! At one point it was over 50 per cent actually, but slowed a little towards the end of May.

Of course a lot of Apple lovers say this is just a blip, and the world will return to sanity in a year or so. But will it?

What Apple has never really been tested with, is competition that's also considered "cool". If there's one company whose services everyone seems to love, it's Google, and a Google vs. Apple (or Android vs. iOS.) is very, very different from Apple vs. Nokia, Sony Ericsson and the likes.

Apple has a very simple mantra to garner success – offer complete solutions. Macs were always cool, and hardware and software was always better integrated than with OSes and x86 hardware, but at the price of being stiflingly restrictive. Games, freeware and piracy contributed to Microsoft's domination of the PC, and ease of use and design has dominated Apple's hold over the high-end cell phone markets.

In India, we like to be able to choose, and to be different. Yes, even now a lot of us would

want an iPhone or an iPad, but we'd also really like to have, say, the option to upgrade said iDevice's storage. Since Google doesn't make hardware, with Android we get a hundred times more choice, across a whole range of price categories.

Even Windows cannot be completely discarded as a mobile operating system just yet. Thanks to regular and frequent updates in mobile hardware, courtesy NVIDIA, ARM, Intel and the rest – we're already seeing dual-core chips on phones. If the trend continues, you're going to see more multi-purpose computing devices in your palm, and that is where Microsoft and Windows shine – although I love both Android and iOS, give me a phone or tablet with the versatility of a laptop, and a battery that lasts a couple of days, and I'll never buy another smart phone! Would you?

Finally, it's the apps that maketh the market these days, and if there's one buzz word that works in India, it's "Free". With almost every app requiring web access to offer you any sort of real functionality, Google's web dominance will surely help Android. Despite having iAd to serve ads and thus enable free app developers to make money, Apple's advertising clout on the web is no match for Google, which makes all its money from advertising.

The fact that Android is open source also means more innovation for the platform, and as a result a freer hand for developers to try and capture our attention. The platform wars have just begun, and the next few years will be key to deciding on who will win. If strategies don't change drastically, I know who I'm putting my money on.



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"What Apple has never really been tested with, is competition that's also considered cool"

A stylized, handwritten signature in black ink, which appears to read 'Robert Sovereign-Smith'.

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